

The Box Keeps Coming

Auditing a Meal-Kit Subscription’s Per-Meal Premium Against the Grocery Shop It Replaces

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Motivation

A meal-kit box prices itself per portion, never per gram — a subscriber comparing it to a grocery shop must do arithmetic the box is not designed to invite. Little is known about what that arithmetic finds, or what a subscriber does once they’ve done it.

Research questions

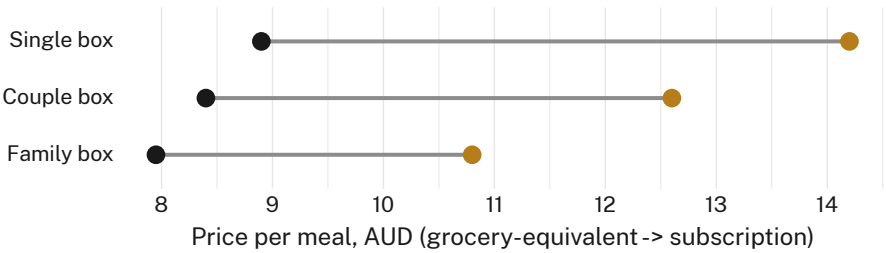
- Audit a household meal-kit subscription’s per-meal cost against a matched grocery-equivalent basket, by tier.
- Test whether an itemised monthly cost breakdown shifts cancellation behaviour.
- Catalogue subscribers’ stated reasons for staying once shown the gap.

Study design

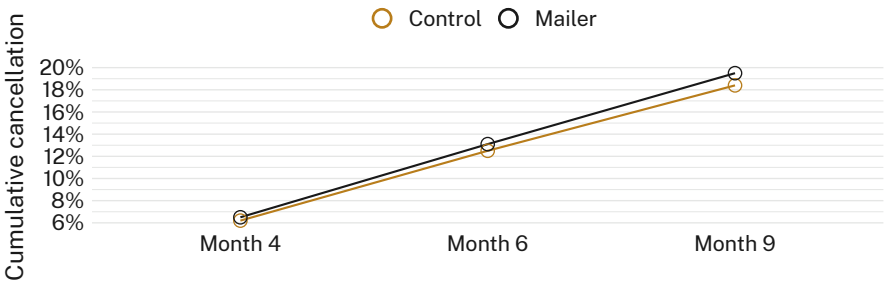
- n = 214 subscriber households · 3 tiers (single, couple, family box) · 9-month audit
- Randomised cost-breakdown mailer vs no-mailer control from month 4
- Grocery-equivalent basket priced weekly at each household’s nearest supermarket; exit interviews at month 9

Findings

The subscription carries a per-meal premium of 36-60% over its grocery-equivalent basket across all three tiers. A randomised itemised breakdown produces no detectable change in month-9 cancellation (19.5% treatment vs 18.4% control, $\Delta = 1.1$ pp, $p = 0.61$).



Per-meal premium runs from 36% (family box) to 60% (single box); the family tier, marketed as the discount option, carries the smallest absolute gap and the same relative one.



Cumulative cancellation tracks within 1.1 percentage points of control at every check-in from month 4 to month 9; the itemised breakdown never opens a gap wide enough to read as a nudge.

Implications & takeaways

Subscribers are not straightforwardly uninformed: exit interviews suggest most had already estimated a premium in this range unprompted, mailer or not. What the breakdown moves is confidence in the estimate, not the decision built on it.

Stated reasons for staying, ranked by frequency across exit interviews:

- “the meals are still better than what I’d plan myself”
- “cancelling means finding the link, and I keep putting it off”
- “the price only really bothers me when the box arrives, not before”

Next: testing whether the same figure, reframed as savings foregone rather than premium paid, finds a lever a plain cost figure does not.

References

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De-identified receipt matching only; no loyalty-card numbers retained.

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